

START HERE

How to play

- 1 Find your child's color.
- 2 Pick a card, or let your child pick.
- 3 Play while it's fun. Stop before it isn't.
- 4 Try the talk tip. Then wait.

 **0–1** year

 **1–2** years

 **2–3** years

 **3–5** years



Every card: a grown-up plays along and stays within reach.

▲ 0–1 yr

01



Peekaboo Cloth

NEEDS A dish towel

👤 From 4 mo

☰ Prep 0 min

💧 No mess

🕒 ~5 min

Hide your face behind the towel, then pop out: “Peekaboo!” Later, let baby pull it off your head.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Pause before “boo.” A kick, a grin or a squeal is baby’s turn.



With a grown-up. Put the towel away after play; never leave it in the crib.

▲ 0–1 yr

02



Copy Cat Faces

NEEDS Just you

👤 From birth

☰ Prep 0 min

💧 No mess

🕒 ~3 min

Hold baby face to face, close enough to see you well. Open wide, smile big, stick out your tongue. Watch baby try it too.



TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

Copy baby's sounds back: "ba" becomes "ba-ba!" Then wait for another.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

03



Kitchen Drum

NEEDS A pot and a wooden spoon



From 6 mo



Prep 1 min



No mess



~5 min

Turn the pot upside down on the floor. Tap it, then hand baby the spoon. Take turns: soft, then loud.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

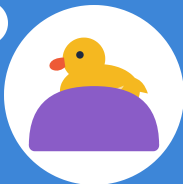
Name the sounds as they happen:
“Bang! Bang! Soft... LOUD!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

04



Where's Duck?

NEEDS A big toy and a towel

 From 6 mo  Prep 1 min  No mess  ~5 min

Hide the toy under the towel with a little bit showing. Ask “Where’s duck?” and let baby find it. Cheer!



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Ask, then count to five in your head before you help.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

05



Bubble Watch

NEEDS Bubbles

👤 From 6 mo ≡ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Blow a few bubbles slowly above baby. Let baby watch, reach and pop. Blow again when baby reaches, kicks or looks.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Use the same short words each time:
“Up, up... pop!”



With a grown-up. You hold the bottle and blow away from baby's face. Wipe little hands.

▲ 0–1 yr

06



Rock and Stop

NEEDS A song you know

👤 From birth

☰ Prep 0 min

💧 No mess

🕒 ~5 min

Hold baby and sway while you sing.
Stop in the middle and wait. Start again
when baby wiggles, coos or looks up.



TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

The pause is the game. Baby's wiggle means "more!"



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

07



Roll It Back

NEEDS A big soft ball

👤 From 7 mo

≡ Prep 1 min

💧 No mess

🕒 ~5 min

For babies who can sit: sit facing each other, legs apart. Roll the ball to baby, then help roll it back.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “Ready... roll!” and wait for a look, a sound or a reach.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

08



First Book Chat

NEEDS A board book

 From 3 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~5 min

Sit baby on your lap. Point to one picture and name it. Let baby pat the pictures and help turn the pages.



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Talk about whatever baby looks at, even the same page again.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

09



In and Out

NEEDS A basket and 4–5 big toys

👤 From 8 mo ⌵ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Drop toys into the basket one by one:
“In!” Tip them out: “Out!” Let baby dump
and fill.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

One word for each move: “in,” “out,” “all gone!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

10



Leaf Hello

NEEDS A tree or a big plant

👤 From 3 mo ≡ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Carry baby close to a tree or a window plant. Touch a leaf together, look up at the sky, feel the breeze.



TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

Name it, then add one word: “Leaf.
Green leaf. Soft leaf.”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Leaves and petals stay out of mouths.

▲ 0–1 yr

11



Tickle Countdown

NEEDS Just you



From 4 mo



Prep 0 min



No mess



~3 min

Wiggle your fingers in the air: “One... two... three...” then a gentle tickle. Do it again, a little slower.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Stop at “two...” A squeal or a kick asks for “three!”



With a grown-up. Gentle tickles only. If baby turns away, stop: that's a turn too.

▲ 0–1 yr

12



Stack and Crash

NEEDS Plastic cups or big blocks

👤 From 6 mo ⌵ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Stack three cups into a tower. Let baby knock it over. Cheer, and build it again together.



TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

Say “up, up, up... crash!” and throw your arms wide on “crash.”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr

13



Sock Off!

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock

👤 From 6 mo

☰ Prep 0 min

💧 No mess

🕒 ~3 min

Slip a big, loose sock halfway onto baby's foot. Let baby pull it off: "Sock off!" Try the other foot.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say it as it happens: "Foot! Sock on... sock off!"



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Put the sock away after play; socks stay out of mouths.

1–2 yrs

14



Box Car

NEEDS A big cardboard box

 From 12 mo  Prep 3 min  No mess  ~10 min

Your toddler sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room. Stop at “stations” to wave hello.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “Ready, set...” and wait for “go!”
Any sound counts.



With a grown-up. Push slowly on the floor. Pull out staples and tape first.

1–2 yrs

15



Stir the Soup

NEEDS A pot, a big spoon, big blocks

 From 12 mo  Prep 1 min  Low mess  ~10 min

Drop blocks into the pot and stir. Blow on the “hot” soup. Serve a spoonful to a teddy.



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Hot soup or cold soup?” Hold up two hands and wait.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

16



Animal Voices

NEEDS Big toy animals or a picture book

 From 12 mo

 Prep 1 min

 No mess

 ~5 min

Hold up an animal and make its sound.
Pass it to your child. Swap animals and
go again.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “The cow says...” and leave a gap
for “moo.”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item
bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

17



Pour and Splash

NEEDS A tub of water, 2 plastic cups

 From 12 mo

 Prep 3 min

 Messy

 ~10 min

Set the tub on a towel. Pour water from cup to cup. Let your child pour, splash and fill.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Talk as it happens: “Full... empty! Pour, pour.”



With a grown-up. Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

1–2 yrs

18



Block Tower

NEEDS Big blocks

 From 14 mo  Prep 1 min  Low mess  ~5 min

Build a tower together, one block each.
Count as you go. Let them knock it down
and start again.



TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

They say “block,” you say “big block!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

19



Hat Parade

NEEDS 3–4 hats from around the house

 From 12 mo

 Prep 2 min

 No mess

 ~5 min

Try on hats in front of a mirror. Make a silly face in each one. March around the room.



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Sun hat or winter hat?” Let them choose yours too.



With a grown-up. Only hats with no ties, cords or pom-poms. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs

20



Pillow Mountain

NEEDS Couch cushions

 From 12 mo  Prep 2 min  Low mess  ~10 min

Pile the cushions on the floor to make a mountain. Help your child climb up, then slide down.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say it as they move: “Up, up, up! Down!”



With a grown-up. On the floor, away from furniture corners. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs

21



Sock Toss

NEEDS Rolled-up pairs of socks, a basket

 From 15 mo  Prep 1 min  Low mess  ~5 min

Toss the sock balls into the basket. Find a big one and a little one. Balance one on your head!



TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE
“Sock” becomes “big sock!” or “red sock!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

22



Teddy's Bedtime

NEEDS A stuffed toy, a small towel

 From 15 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~5 min

Tuck teddy in with the towel. Read teddy a book, sing teddy a song, whisper “night-night.”



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

If they feed teddy instead, talk about the snack.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

23



Chair Tunnel

NEEDS Two chairs and a blanket

 From 12 mo  Prep 3 min  No mess  ~10 min

Drape the blanket over two chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through together, then take turns.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say the word as they move: “In... through... out!”



With a grown-up. Use sturdy chairs that won't tip. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs

24



Clap and Stomp

NEEDS Just you



From 12 mo



Prep 0 min



No mess



~3 min

Clap twice, stomp twice, pat your knees.
Let your child copy you, then you copy
their moves.



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Copy whatever they do. They're the
leader now.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item
bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs

25



Pull-Out Box

NEEDS An empty tissue box, 6 washcloths

 From 12 mo  Prep 2 min  Low mess  ~5 min

Stuff the washcloths into the box. Your child pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and go again.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Hold one up: “More?” Wait for a look, a point or a sound.



With a grown-up. Pull out the plastic film from the box opening first. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs

26



Kick and Chase

NEEDS A big soft ball

 From 15 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~10 min

Roll or kick the ball across the room.
Race to it together. Catch it and sit on it!



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Kick it or roll it?” Show both, then wait.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

27



Blanket Fort

NEEDS A blanket, chairs, pillows

 From 24 mo  Prep 5 min  Low mess  ~15 min

Build a fort together. Bring in a book and a teddy. Read inside, then peek out the door.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Use place words: “in,” “under,” “on top,” “behind.”



With a grown-up. Sturdy chairs only; nothing heavy on top. Stay within reach.

★ 2–3 yrs

28



Tea Party

NEEDS Plastic cups and plates, stuffed toys

🕒 From 24 mo ≡ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Set a pretend table for the toys. Pour pretend tea, pass pretend cake, and clink cups: “Cheers!”



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask as Bear: “More tea? Milk or honey?”
Wait for the answer.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

29



Color Sort

NEEDS Big blocks in 3 colors, 3 bowls

 From 26 mo  Prep 2 min  Low mess  ~10 min

Put one of each color in a bowl. Your child sorts the rest. Mix them all up and sort again.



TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

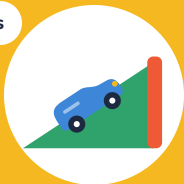
“Red” becomes “red block goes here!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

30



Car Ramp

NEEDS A board or big book, big toy cars

👤 From 24 mo ≡ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Prop the board on the sofa to make a ramp. Race the cars down. Which one goes the farthest?



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say what happens: “Fast! Slow! Crash!”



With a grown-up. Only cars bigger than a toilet-paper tube, with no loose wheels.

★ 2–3 yrs

31



Big Paper Art

NEEDS Big paper, jumbo egg-shaped crayons, tape

 From 24 mo  Prep 2 min  Low mess  ~10 min

Tape the paper to the floor. Draw lines, dots and circles side by side. Swap crayons now and then.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Describe, don't quiz: "Round and round. A big circle!"



With a grown-up. Crayons too big to fit in a toilet-paper tube. Toss broken bits.

★ 2–3 yrs

32



Freeze Dance

NEEDS A song to sing or play

 From 24 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~5 min

Dance to a song. When the music stops, freeze! Take turns being the one who stops the music.



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

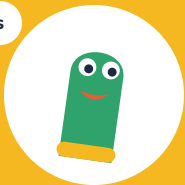
Let your child shout “stop!” and “go!” for you.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

33



Sock Friend Chat

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock, a marker (yours)

 From 24 mo

 Prep 2 min

 No mess

 ~5 min

Draw eyes on the sock and slip it on your hand. Your sock friend says hello, asks a question, then waits.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Sock friends are patient. Give extra time to answer.



With a grown-up. Draw the face on: no buttons or stick-on eyes. You keep the marker.

★ 2–3 yrs

34



Nature Basket

NEEDS A basket, a walk outside

 From 24 mo  Prep 0 min  Low mess  ~15 min

Collect big leaves, sticks and pinecones. At home, sort them: bumpy, smooth, big, small.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name how they feel: “Bumpy pinecone. Smooth stick.”



With a grown-up. Only things bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms. Wash hands after.

★ 2–3 yrs

35



Pretend Shop

NEEDS Empty food boxes, a bag

👤 From 26 mo ≡ Prep 3 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Set up a shop on the sofa. Your child fills the bag and pays you with a high five. Then swap jobs.



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Cereal or crackers today?” and wait.



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

36



Toy Bath

NEEDS A tub of water, a washable toy, a cloth

 From 24 mo  Prep 3 min  Messy  ~10 min

Give the toy a bath: wash its hands, feet and tummy. Dry it off and tuck it in.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name body parts: “Wash the toes. Now the knees!”



With a grown-up. Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

★ 2–3 yrs

37



Animal Moves

NEEDS Space to move



From 24 mo



Prep 0 min



No mess



~5 min

Hop like a frog, stomp like an elephant, tiptoe like a cat. Take turns picking the animal.



TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

Add the sound and the move: “Hop, hop, ribbit!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

38



Shape Hunt

NEEDS Just you

 From 30 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~10 min

Walk around the house looking for circles: a plate, a clock, a wheel. Then hunt for squares.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Point and name: “Round, like the clock!”



With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

39



Little Helper

NEEDS A cloth damp with plain water

👤 From 24 mo ≡ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Wipe the table together after a meal.
Then let your child wipe a chair, then a toy.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Talk as you work: “Wipe, wipe. All clean!”



With a grown-up. Plain water only: no sprays or wipes. Stay within reach.

● 3–5 yrs

40



Story Box

NEEDS A box, 3 toys from around the house

 From 36 mo  Prep 2 min  No mess  ~10 min

Pull out 3 toys. Make up a story that uses all three. Take turns adding one sentence each.



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Let the story go anywhere. Ask, “And then what?”



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

41



Obstacle Course

NEEDS Pillows, a chair, a blanket

👤 From 36 mo ≡ Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Build a course: crawl under the chair, hop over the pillows, roll across the blanket.



TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Give two-step directions: “Crawl under, then jump!” Then swap.



With a grown-up. Clear the space of sharp corners. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

42



I Spy Colors

NEEDS Just you



From 36 mo



Prep 0 min



No mess



~5 min

“I spy something green.” Your child guesses. Then they pick something and give you the clue.



TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

If they get stuck, add a hint: “It’s round...”



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

43



Restaurant

NEEDS Paper, crayons, plates

 From 36 mo  Prep 5 min  Low mess  ~15 min

Draw a menu together. Your child takes your order, “cooks” it and brings it to the table. Swap roles.



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

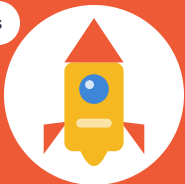
Ask “Soup or pizza? Anything else?”



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

44



Box Rocket

NEEDS A big box, crayons

👤 From 36 mo ≡ Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Draw buttons and windows on the box.
Climb in, count down from ten, and blast
off to the moon.



TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Ask “Where are we flying? What’s out
the window?”



With a grown-up. Pull out staples and tape first.
A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

45



Kitchen List

NEEDS Paper, a crayon

👤 From 42 mo ≡ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Draw a list together: an apple, a cup, a spoon. Hunt for each one in the kitchen and check it off.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Found the spoon! What’s next on our list?”



With a grown-up. You choose the list. Knives, the stove and cleaners stay off it.

● 3–5 yrs

46



Do What I Do

NEEDS Just you



From 36 mo



Prep 0 min



No mess



~5 min

Touch your nose, hop on one foot, spin around once. Your child copies. Then they're the leader.



TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Being the leader means practicing clear directions.



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

47



Shadow Animals

NEEDS A flashlight, a wall

 From 36 mo  Prep 2 min  No mess  ~10 min

Dim the lights. Shine the flashlight on a wall and make hand shadows: a bird, a dog, a crocodile.



TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Ask “What animal is this?” Let them guess, then try a new one.



With a grown-up. A grown-up holds the flashlight. Battery covers stay shut.

● 3–5 yrs

48



Book Bridge

NEEDS Books or blocks, toy cars

 From 36 mo  Prep 3 min  Low mess  ~10 min

Build a bridge between two stacks. Drive cars over it. Make it longer. Will it hold?



TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

Say “I wonder if it will hold?” Then wait and see.



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

49



Sock Match

NEEDS A pile of clean socks

👤 From 36 mo ≡ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Dump the socks out. Race to find matching pairs. Roll each pair into a ball.



TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Hold up two: “Same or different?”



With a grown-up. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

50



Water Painting

NEEDS A cup of water, a paintbrush

👤 From 36 mo ⌵ Prep 2 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Outside, “paint” a fence, a step or the sidewalk with water. Watch the picture dry and disappear.



TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

“Where did it go? I wonder if the sun dried it.”



With a grown-up. Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach, away from the street.

● 3–5 yrs

51



Feelings Faces

NEEDS A wall mirror or an unbreakable one

 From 36 mo  Prep 0 min  No mess  ~5 min

Make faces in the mirror together: happy, sad, surprised, grumpy. Guess each other's face.



TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Your eyebrows went up. Surprised!”
Ask when they felt that way.



With a grown-up. Use a wall mirror or an unbreakable one. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

52



Sound Walk

NEEDS A walk outside

👤 From 36 mo ≡ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~15 min

Stand still and listen. Count sounds on your fingers: a bird, a car, the wind. Walk on and listen again.



TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Whisper “What do you hear?” Take turns naming sounds.



With a grown-up. Hold hands near the street. A grown-up stays close.

MAKE IT YOURS



Your own play

TITLE

NEEDS

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages:

0-1

1-2

2-3

3-5